

# AFÁRÁ

An Entrepreneurship Accelerator for African Women in Energy & Infrastructure

A Concept Note

## About Afára



**AFARA** is an initiative powered by **Open Spaces & Bridges Advisory (OPSB)**.

Created to increase funding success and operational support for women-led businesses in Africa's energy and infrastructure sectors.

# Vision

To enable, support and scale 50 female-owned businesses in Africa's energy and infrastructure sectors over five years by providing holistic personal development, project development, and funding support to the sum of 1bn USD. Through our accelerator program, we will build a pipeline of women entrepreneurs driving scalable, sustainable projects, fostering innovation, clean energy, sustainable infrastructure and climate action.



# Cultural Relevance & Context



The accelerator's name is derived from the Yoruba word "**Afára**," which means "bridge."

which symbolises connection, transition, and opportunity. Afára exists to help women move from feasibility to funding, from aspiration to execution. rooted in Nigerian culture and committed to African identity, Afára brings a global outlook to innovation, leadership, and infrastructure transformation.

# Problem Statement

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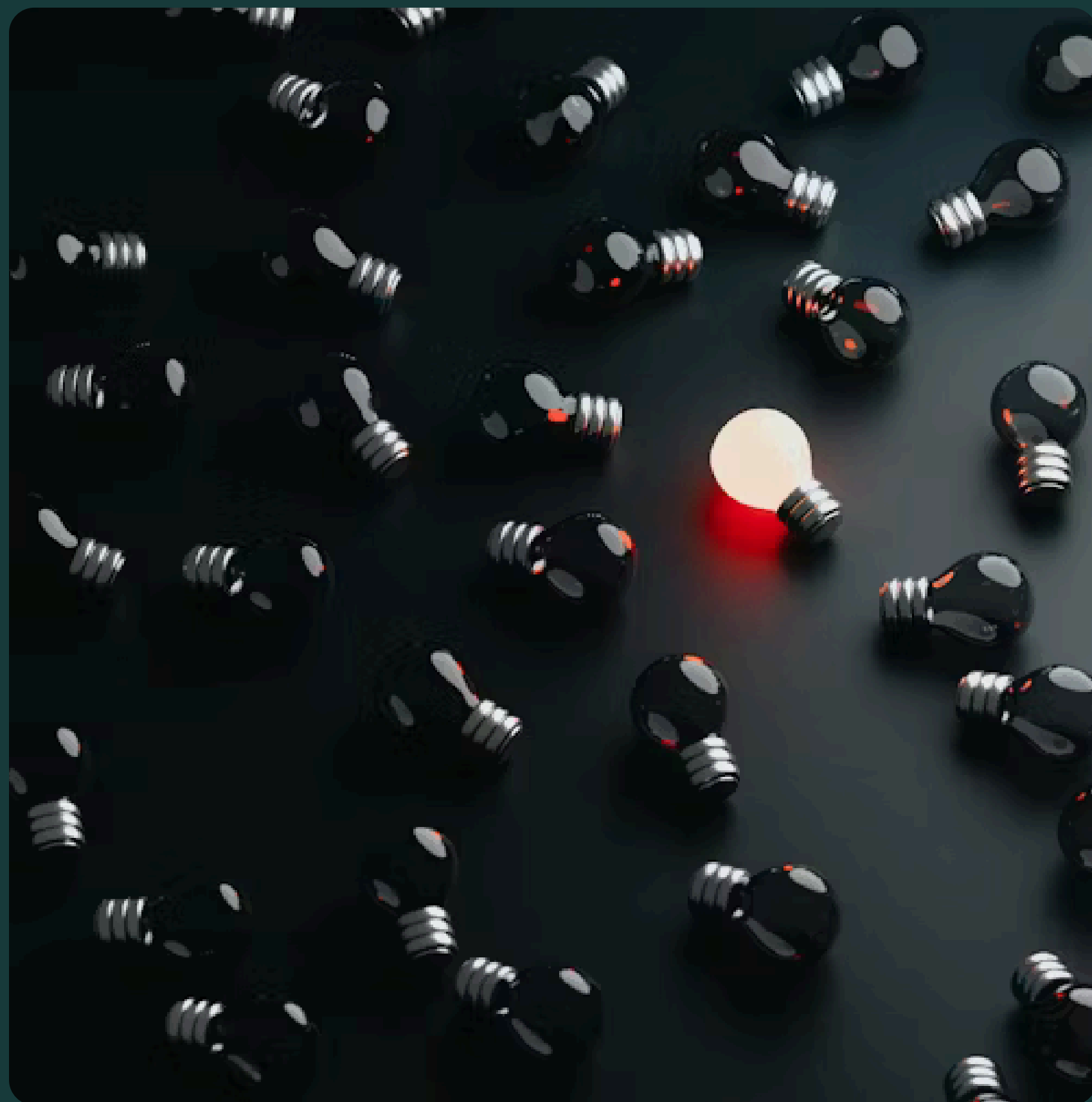
## The Challenge:

- Women are underrepresented in energy and infrastructure despite high entrepreneurial activity across Africa.
- Less than 5% of venture capital goes to women-led startups, creating a \$42B funding gap.
- Few accelerator programs offer technical, financial, and regulatory support tailored to these sectors.
- Structural biases and policy hurdles limit access to procurement, financing, and leadership roles.

## Afára's Response:

- Support 50 women-led ventures with funding, technical expertise, and regulatory guidance.
- Provide end-to-end project development support from concept to capital.
- Build a peer-led mentorship model that multiplies impact through women mentoring women.



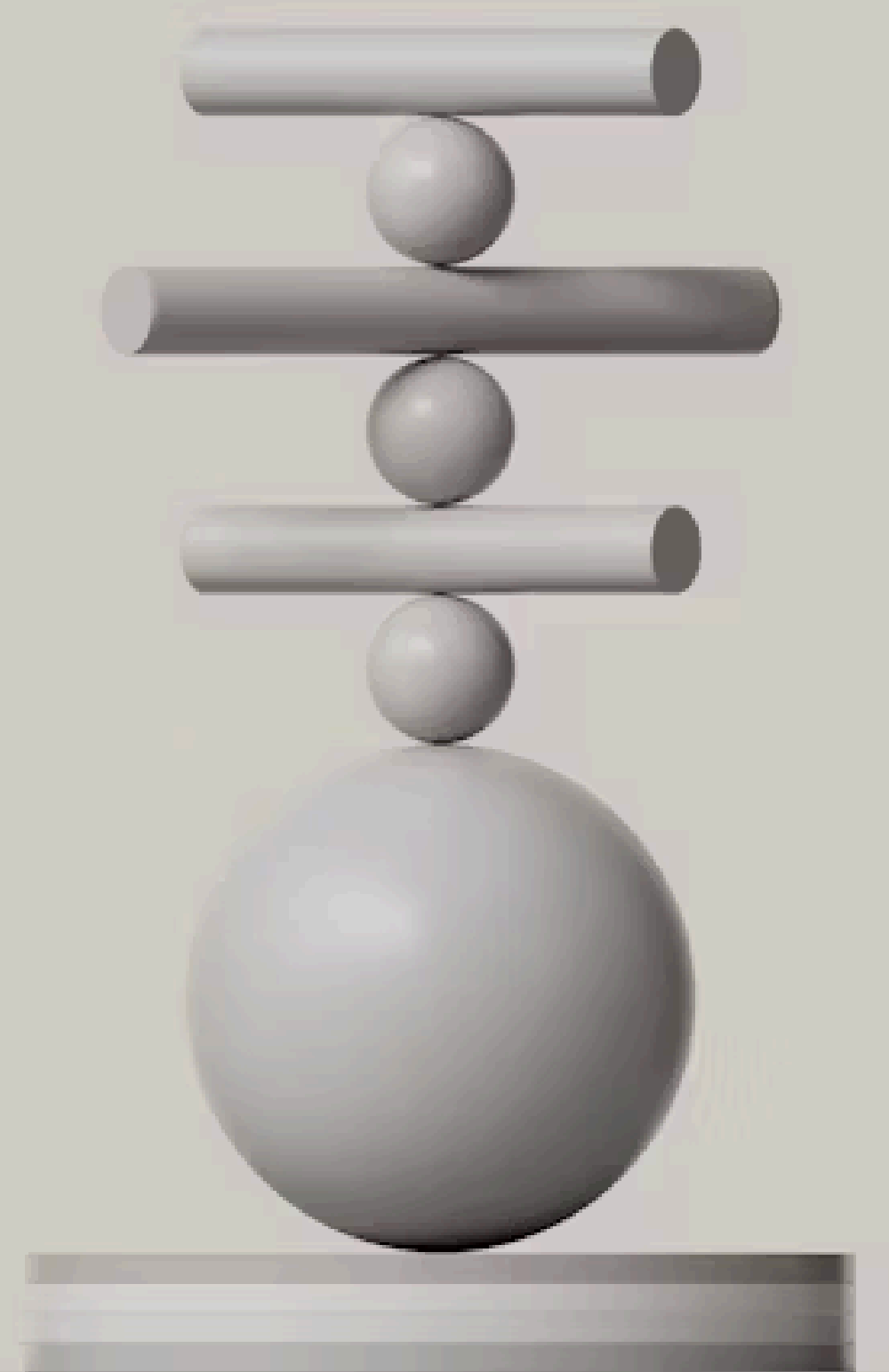


## Afára's Value Proposition

- Wider Coverage- Our coverage is across Africa - East, West, South and North Africa
- Our core focus is on entrepreneurs in the Energy and Infrastructure space with development impact, including energy, roads, rail, ports, transportation, logistics, digital infrastructure, water and sanitation, and clean cooking.
- Funding Aspiration - Our funding aspiration of 1bn USD over 5 years is a mere fraction - less than 1% of what Africa requires annually to meet its infrastructure gap, 130-170bn USD per year
- Project-Based Support - Accelerator support is project-based, while we also provide holistic support to the infrapreneur.
- Multiplier Model- For sustainability and to ensure that we grow the number of female infrapreneurs, infrapreneurs who have gone through the program must commit to mentoring and supporting at least two other infrapreneurs
- Growth & Ownership Potential - In the mid-term, Infrapreneurs who have gone through the accelerator will be part of a network where they can leverage each other's resources, experience, give back and also own interests in the accelerator



# Operating Model



- **Annual Incubator:** Select 10 female entrepreneurs annually for a program focused on the holistic development of the female entrepreneur from building confidence, audacity, capacity, visibility, project development support, project viability, funding, and financial close.
- **Training Programs:** Provide technical, financial, soft skills, and governance training tailored to female infrapreneurs.
- **Advocacy:** Promote gender mainstreaming in energy/infrastructure for private sector and governments through toolkits and engagement across the continent.
- **Consulting & TA Support:** Offer subsidized consulting services to female infrapreneurs and facilitate technical assistance for initiatives and programs by development finance and financial institutions in the energy and infrastructure space.

## Our Key Focus Areas

### 1. **Projects, Transaction Advisory & Structuring**

From concept to capital—we guide the entire development process, ensuring technical and financial viability.

### 2. **Regulatory Strategy**

Navigating policy with confidence—we demystify early-stage regulatory hurdles to boost bankability.

### 3. **Team Selection & Procurement**

Curating capable, aligned project teams through hands-on selection and procurement support.

### 4. **Funding Strategy & Capital Matchmaking**

We shape funding strategies and connect projects to the right capital partners via our extensive network.

### 5. **Strategic Add-Ons**

- Incubation and Powering of AFARA Female Entrepreneur Accelerator Program
- Market Entry Support
- Ad-hoc Project/Transaction Strategy Sessions
- Facilitation of Industry Events
- Capacity-Building Workshops
- Technical Assistance Program Design & Coordination



# Founder & Lead Advisor



**Dolapo  
Kukoyi**

A renowned energy and infrastructure strategist, legal expert, and governance leader with over 20 years of experience driving high-impact projects across Africa. As a Managing and Senior Partner at Detail Commercial Solicitors, she has led complex transactions in energy, climate finance, and investment strategy, guiding organizations through regulatory frameworks, financial structuring, and sustainable growth.

She serves on multiple boards, including Kowry Energy (Berlin & Africa), Arctic Infrastructure, and the Nigerian Economic Summit Group, where she shapes investment policies, governance frameworks, and climate finance strategies. Her expertise has been recognized by IFLR 1000, Chambers, and Who's Who Legal, cementing her reputation as a leading voice in private capital mobilization, energy transition, and regulatory reform.

Beyond her executive leadership, Dolapo is committed to fostering female leadership in infrastructure and energy. Through Open Spaces & Bridges (OPSB), she provides strategic advisory, funding readiness support, and leadership development to help women-led businesses move from feasibility to execution. Her work is shaping a future where women are not just participants but pioneers in the sector, driving Africa's industrial and economic transformation.

## Partner & Senior Finance Advisor



**Babatunde  
Ajayi**

Babatunde is a professional with 20 years of experience in providing financing and structuring solutions to corporate and public sector clients in Africa. He is passionate about the development and integrity of financial markets, having witnessed first-hand, their impact on the prosperity and well-being of businesses, peoples and the wider economy. During his career, Babatunde has led or participated in transactions with a total value of about \$4 billion.

He has served as Director of Capital Markets for the Capitalsage Holdings Group (a group with interests in agriculture, financial services and healthcare), where he raised nearly \$90 million from international DFI's to finance growth of the agribusiness subsidiary. Previously, Babatunde served as Head, Capital Markets and Advisory Services at United Capital Plc, where he led capital raising transactions for some of Nigeria's leading corporates, financial institutions and municipalities. He also led the investment banking consortium which closed Nigeria's first power sector bond issuance without a credit guarantee. He holds an Executive Masters in Finance at INSEAD, an M.Sc. in Finance & Economic Policy from University of London, as well as a Bachelors' degree in Finance.

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## Adviser & Technical Asst



**Nenritmwa  
Gotodok Gofup**

Nenritmwa is an accomplished energy lawyer and climate advocate with over seven years of experience spanning legal advisory, energy policy, sustainability, and ecosystem development. She currently serves as Managing Partner at TSL Hub, where she leads strategy and implementation for high-impact energy and infrastructure projects. Her work has positioned her at the intersection of law, innovation, and clean energy solutions—advising regulatory agencies like the Nigerian Electricity Regulatory Commission (NERC), facilitating multi-stakeholder engagements, and helping structure capital-intensive projects, including a ₦170 billion energy concession.

Nenritmwa's credentials include an LLM in Energy Law from the University of Ibadan and multiple certifications in renewable energy technologies and arbitration. She is a member of the Nigerian Bar Association, the Renewable Energy Association of Nigeria (REAN), and the African Women in Energy Development Initiative (AWEDI). Passionate about accelerating Africa's energy transition, she continues to advocate for inclusive policies, sustainable practices, and strategic partnerships that address energy poverty and climate vulnerability across the continent.



## Our Advisory Board

Made up of experienced people (women and men) who have built or financed businesses in the infrastructure and energy space.

Reputable leaders of financial institutions development finance institutions, infrastructure funds, PE, Venture capital funds and philanthropies who have an interest in developing women entrepreneurs and would be willing to commit time, resources and influence to supporting female entrepreneurs.





## Partners & Endorsers

Organizations, institutions, funds, non-profits and philanthropies that provide support, development finance, and technical assistance to women in the African Energy and Infrastructure space.

We will also be looking to partner with legal and financial advisory firms that would be interested in providing time and resources to this cause.

Women Associations in the Energy Infrastructure space are also key partners for us because they would feed our pipeline and would be our Endorsers.

# Why You Should Support Afára As An Individual



## **Build a Legacy of Empowerment**

By supporting AFARA, you are investing in women who will shape Africa's energy and infrastructure future. This is your chance to be part of something that outlives you—a legacy of empowerment, innovation, and sustainable development.

## **Empower Women, Transform Nations**

There's a saying: "Educate a woman, and you educate a nation." Women carry not only dreams but the power to transform communities. Backing female entrepreneurs in energy and infrastructure means you're lighting up homes, powering schools, and building roads to a better future.

## **Do Your Part for the Planet and the Continent**

Your contribution supports the achievement of global goals—SDGs 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 13 and 17—in one of the regions that needs it most.

## **Be a Catalyst**

Each woman we support is committed to mentoring two others. That's exponential impact. That's your name behind a ripple effect of change.





# Why You Should Support Afará As An Institution

## **Strategic Alignment with Your Mission**

If your organization has—or is developing—a gender-lens investing strategy, AFARA offers a ready-made, high-impact vehicle. Our model directly advances equity and economic inclusion in sectors where women remain underrepresented but deeply needed.

## **Deliver Tangible, Measurable Impact**

Partnering with AFARA isn't just CSR—it's targeted impact investing. We help close Africa's critical infrastructure and energy gaps while empowering a pipeline of scalable, women-owned ventures. It's where social impact meets economic returns.

## **Advance the SDGs at Scale**

AFARA directly contributes to SDGs 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 11, and 13, delivering measurable outcomes in clean energy, sustainable infrastructure, and climate resilience. Your support is a step toward fulfilling both global development goals and your ESG commitments.

## **Shape the Future of Africa's Industrial Revolution**

Women entrepreneurs are key to Africa's transformation. Through incubation, funding facilitation, and strategic guidance, AFARA enables women to become the industrial architects of Africa's future—and your organization can be instrumental in that shift.

## **Multiply Your Influence**

Our unique “Chain of Impact” model ensures that every woman empowered pays it forward by uplifting two more. Your support doesn't stop with one—it grows across generations and communities.

# Sustainable Impact

Afara's goals align well with the following UN Sustainable Development Goals



# Talking Points

- Corporate Structure and Location of The Accelerator
- Mode and Duration of Accelerator Program
- Eligibility Criteria
- Curriculum Design
- Faculty



# Lend Your Support Right Away!



Are you interested in collaborating with Dolapo and the team at OPSB on bringing AFARA to life? Please send an email to [dolapo@openspacedandbridges.com](mailto:dolapo@openspacedandbridges.com).

Thank You

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